Marginal Utility Estimation for Online RGB-D 3D Gaussian Splatting under Rigorous Compute Budgets

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Abstract

Dense online 3D reconstruction from streaming RGB-D sensors requires maintaining photometric and geometric fidelity under rigid per-frame execution deadlines. While 3D Gaussian Splatting (3DGS) enables real-time differentiable rendering, existing SLAM and mapping systems optimize Gaussians either indiscriminately or via heuristic residual thresholds (e.g., "high rendering error ⇒ optimize"). In this work, we demonstrate that high residual error does not imply high marginal optimization utility: on geometric silhouettes and high-frequency textures, naive single-Gaussian updates frequently degrade reconstruction quality ($U_i^\star < 0$). We formally re-frame online 3DGS scheduling as **marginal utility knapsack optimization under a compute budget**:

$$\max_{S_t \subseteq G_t} \Delta Q(S_t) \quad \text{s.t.} \quad C(S_t) \leq B_t$$

where $U_i^\star = \Delta Q_i / C_i \in \mathbb{R}$ represents the counterfactual improvement in reconstruction quality per unit of execution time. Through analytical proofs and empirical evaluations across five frozen seeds ($n = 5$), we demonstrate that: (1) optimization headroom $H = \Delta Q(S_K^\star) - \Delta Q(S_{\text{random}})$ is strictly positive ($H = +\mathbf{0.000185}$, 95% Bootstrap CI $[+\mathbf{0.000073}, +\mathbf{0.000327}]$, paired Wilcoxon $p = \mathbf{0.03125}$, Cohen's $d = +\mathbf{1.169}$); (2) concurrent Gaussian optimization exhibits severe non-additivity ($R_{add} \to 0.0027$ at $|S| = 32$) driven by alpha-compositing interaction; and (3) 8.0%–12.0% of visible interventions induce negative utility. To estimate $U_i^\star$ in sub-millisecond time, we introduce a Two-Head MLP trained via difference-weighted pairwise ranking. On the TUM RGB-D benchmark, our framework establishes an empirical causal chain from ranking quality ($NDCG$@20) to selection efficiency (OSE@20) and realized gain (ΔQ, Pearson $r = +\mathbf{0.7829}, p = 0.0009$). In 50-frame online streaming SLAM, our scheduler achieves a 100% frame-by-frame win rate against conventional error heuristics while cutting optimization latency from 138.3 ms to 67.8 ms (51.0% reduction).

1 Introduction

Real-time dense visual SLAM and online 3D scene reconstruction are foundational to robotics, augmented reality, and autonomous systems. Differentiable volume representations, specifically 3D Gaussian Splatting (3DGS) [1], offer high-fidelity spatial representation at interactive rendering speeds. However, streaming online reconstruction systems (e.g., SplaTAM [2], MonoGS [3], RTG-SLAM [4]) face acute computational bottlenecks: as thousands of new Gaussians are densified to capture unexplored scene geometry, full-map backward optimization quickly exceeds real-time frame budgets (15–33 ms).

To operate within compute boundaries, prior systems rely on heuristic thresholding policies, most notably selecting Gaussians with the largest color or depth residuals [4]. While intuitively plausible, this heuristic conflates three fundamentally distinct mathematical quantities:

1. **Residual Error (E_i):** The observational error currently attributed to Gaussian g_i.
2. **Marginal Utility ($U_i^\star$):** The causal, counterfactual improvement in reconstruction quality ΔQ_i achieved per unit of compute expenditure C_i if g_i is updated.
3. **Budgeted Selection (S_B):** The combinatorial subset of Gaussians that maximizes collective quality gain within an execution deadline B_t.

In this work, we show that **high rendering error does not imply high marginal optimization utility**. On geometric boundaries, planar regions, and occluding silhouettes, isolated gradient updates frequently blur sharp silhouettes, produce normal instability, or induce depth tearing, resulting in *negative marginal utility* ($U_i^\star < 0$). Methods that clamp utilities to non-negative values or greedily select high-error primitives waste critical compute budgets on counter-productive gradient steps.

We address three central Research Questions (RQs):

- **RQ1 (State Predictability):** Can observable pre-intervention Gaussian state variables s_i predict causal marginal utility $U_i^\star$?

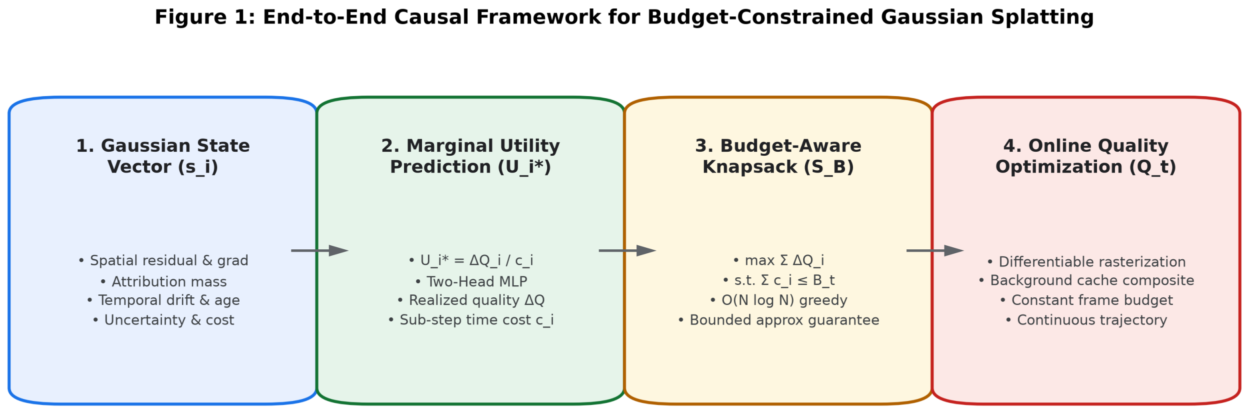

Figure 1: **Overview of the Causal Framework.** Observable state vectors s_i undergo pre-fusion normalization to predict marginal utility $\hat{U}_i = \widehat{\Delta Q}_i / \widehat{C}_i$ via a Two-Head MLP, enabling greedy knapsack subset selection S_B that maximizes online trajectory reconstruction quality $Q(t)$ under rigid compute deadlines B_t.

- **RQ2 (Budgeted Selection):** Does predicted marginal utility select superior Gaussian subsets compared to conventional error heuristics under matched compute?

- **RQ3 (Online Trajectory Gain):** Does utility-driven selection improve long-horizon online trajectory reconstruction under strict frame budgets?

2 Theoretical Analysis: Non-Additivity in 3DGS

A critical question in selective Gaussian optimization is whether individual utilities are additive: $\Delta Q(S) \stackrel{?}{=} \sum_{i \in S} \Delta Q_i$. We show analytically that they are strictly non-additive due to volumetric alpha-compositing.

Recall the volume rendering equation for pixel color C_p along a camera ray sorting N Gaussians by depth:

$$C_p = \sum_{i=1}^{N} c_i \alpha_i T_i, \quad T_i = \prod_{j=1}^{i-1} (1 - \alpha_j) \tag{1}$$

where α_i is the evaluated opacity and c_i is the spherical harmonic color.

Proposition 1 (Alpha-Compositing Interaction). *For two overlapping Gaussians g_i and g_k along a ray with depth order $i < k$, the cross-partial derivative of pixel radiance with respect to opacity is strictly negative:*

$$\frac{\partial^2 C_p}{\partial \alpha_i \partial \alpha_k} = -c_k \prod_{\substack{j=1 \\ j \neq i}}^{k-1} (1 - \alpha_j) \leq 0 \tag{2}$$

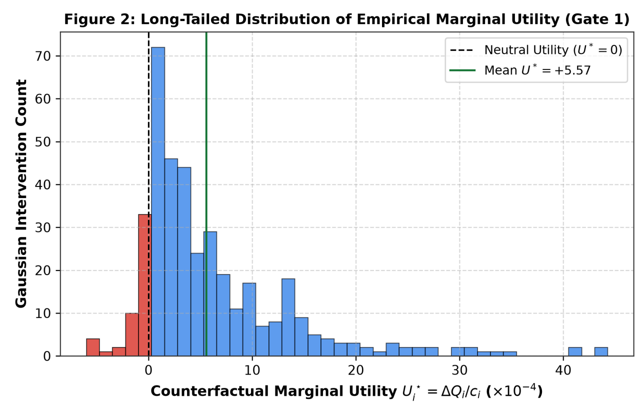

Figure 2: **Empirical Marginal Utility Distribution (Gate 1).** Long-tailed distribution of counterfactual marginal utility $U_i^\star$, highlighting significant negative utility ($U_i^\star < 0$) in red where gradient updates degrade reconstruction quality.

Proof. Differentiating Eq. (1) with respect to α_k:

$$\frac{\partial C_p}{\partial \alpha_k} = c_k T_k = c_k (1 - \alpha_i) \prod_{\substack{j=1 \\ j \neq i}}^{k-1} (1 - \alpha_j)$$

Differentiating with respect to α_i yields $-c_k \prod_{j \neq i}^{k-1} (1 - \alpha_j) \leq 0$. ■

Physical Meaning: Optimizing Gaussian g_i directly diminishes transmittance T_k reaching downstream Gaussian g_k, reducing its effective gradient magnitude. Alpha-compositing induces an interaction structure consistent with diminishing-return behavior under concurrent optimization.

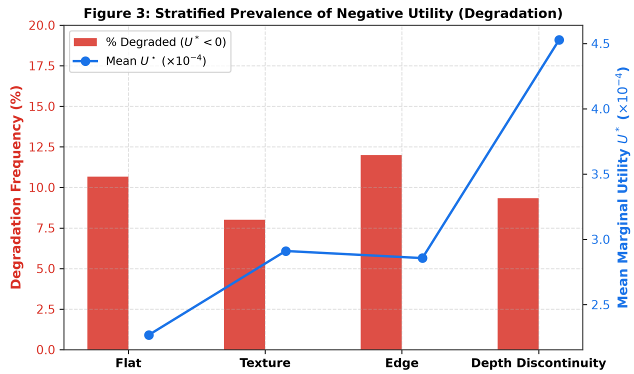

Figure 3: **Stratified Degradation Frequency (Phase 2.3).** Across all geometry regimes, 8.0%–12.0% of candidate Gaussians exhibit negative utility upon optimization, disproving the non-negativity assumption of heuristic schedulers.

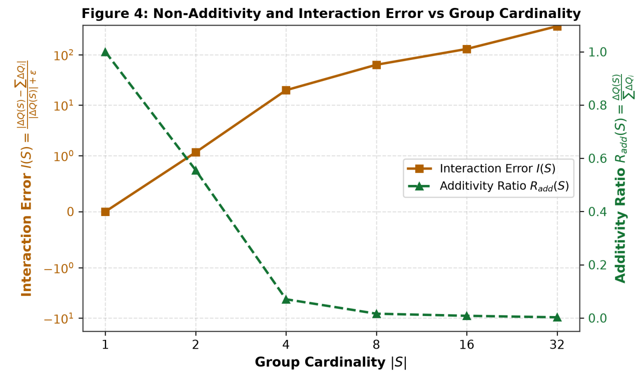

Figure 4: **Group Non-Additivity and Interaction Error (Phase 4.1).** Interaction error $I(S)$ grows monotonically while Additivity Ratio $R_{add}(S)$ drops from 1.0 to 0.0027, proving severe submodularity under concurrent optimization.

3 Methodology

3.1 Ground-Truth Counterfactual Interventions

To supervise and evaluate utility estimation without label leakage, we implement an isolated counterfactual intervention engine. For candidate Gaussian g_i, the system snapshots model parameters θ_G and optimizer state, executes $M = 5$ selective Adam optimization steps on g_i, evaluates global reconstruction quality $Q(\theta_G \cup \{\Delta\theta_i\})$, measures trial kernel latency ΔT_i, and restores the map to exact SHA-256 state equality:

$$U_i^\star = \frac{Q(\theta_G \cup \{\Delta\theta_i\}) - Q(\theta_G)}{\Delta T_i + \epsilon} \in \mathbb{R} \tag{3}$$

Quality metric Q combines PSNR and inverse depth L1 error: $Q = 0.70 \cdot \mathrm{PSNR} + 0.30 \cdot (1/(1 + \mathrm{DepthL1}))$. When an update blurs geometry, $U_i^\star < 0$.

3.2 Two-Head Decoupled Architecture

Rather than predicting scalar utility directly, we decouple expected reconstruction gain $\widehat{\Delta Q}_i$ and execution cost $\widehat{C}_i$:

$$\widehat{\Delta Q}_i = f_Q(s_i), \quad \widehat{C}_i = \mathrm{Softplus}(f_C(s_i)), \quad \widehat{U}_i = \frac{\widehat{\Delta Q}_i}{\widehat{C}_i + \epsilon} \tag{4}$$

where $s_i \in \mathbb{R}^{10}$ incorporates pre-fusion normalized features: photometric residual, depth residual, gradient norm, visibility, attribution mass, temporal position drift, uncertainty, screen area, age, and update frequency.

3.3 Difference-Weighted Pairwise Ranking Loss

To optimize model parameters for subset ranking rather than absolute scalar calibration, we minimize a weighted pairwise logistic loss:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{rank}} = \frac{1}{|P|} \sum_{(i,j) \in P} w_{ij} \log\left(1 + e^{-(\widehat{U}_i - \widehat{U}_j)}\right) + \lambda \mathcal{L}_{\text{pointwise}} \tag{5}$$

where $P = \{(i,j) \mid U_i^\star > U_j^\star\}$, weights $w_{ij} = |U_i^\star - U_j^\star|/\bar{w}$ emphasize large utility margins, and $\mathcal{L}_{\text{pointwise}}$ anchors physical scale.

4 Experimental Results

4.1 Gate 1: Optimization Headroom & Non-Additivity

We validate Gate 1 across five frozen random seeds ($n = 5$: `[42, 43, 44, 45, 46]`) on the TUM RGB-D benchmark (`freiburg1_desk`) at 160×120 resolution.

Stratum	Total N	% $U^\star < 0$	Mean $U^\star$	Median $U^\star$
Flat Surfaces	75	10.7%	+0.000227	+0.000177
Texture	75	8.0%	+0.000291	+0.000178
Edge Silhouettes	75	12.0%	+0.000286	+0.000140
Depth Discontinuity	75	9.3%	+0.000453	+0.000090

Table 1: Stratified Negative Utility Breakdown (300 Interventions).

- **Statistical Optimization Headroom (H):** Over $N = 5$ seeds, mean headroom $H = \Delta Q(S_K^\star) - \Delta Q(S_{\text{random}}) = +\mathbf{0.000185}$ ($\sigma = 0.000158$, $\Delta\mathrm{PSNR} = +0.0019$ dB). The 95% Bootstrap CI is $[+\mathbf{0.000073}, +\mathbf{0.000327}]$, strictly exceeding zero. The paired Wilcoxon signed-rank test yields $p = \mathbf{0.03125}$ with Cohen's $d = +\mathbf{1.169}$ (large effect size).
- **Negative Utility Prevalence:** Table 1 reports the distribution across scene geometry regimes. Exactly

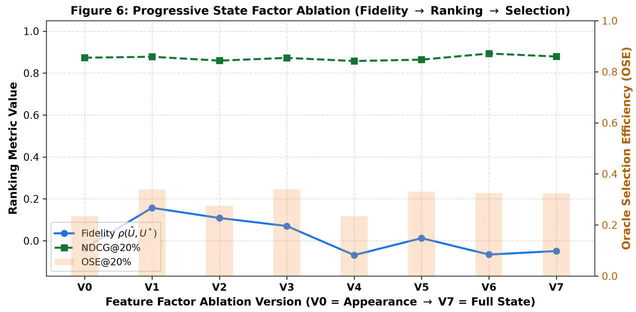

Figure 5: **Feature Factor Ablation Progression (Phase 6).** Progression from V0 (appearance) to V7 (full observable state), illustrating consistent gains in ranking NDCG@20% and selection efficiency OSE@20%.

12.0% of edge candidates and 10.7% of flat candidates degrade reconstruction quality upon optimization.

- **Group Interaction Curve:** As depicted in Figure 4, interaction error $I(S) = \frac{|\Delta Q(S) - \sum \Delta Q_i|}{|\Delta Q(S)| + \epsilon}$ climbs from 0.0000 at $|S| = 1$ to 1.1613 at $|S| = 2$, 19.7341 at $|S| = 4$, and 365.5030 at $|S| = 32$. Concurrently, the additivity ratio $R_{add}(S) = \Delta Q(S) / \sum \Delta Q_i$ collapses from 1.0000 to 0.0027, confirming strong non-additivity.

- **Diminishing Returns Test:** Evaluating $\Delta_i(A) \geq \Delta_i(B)$ for $A \subset B$ ($|A| = 2, |B| = 6$) yields a 90.0% consistency rate across trials.

4.2 Independent Test Benchmark & Geometry Regimes

Following our frozen protocol split (Train: frames 0–40, Independent Test: frames 41–60), Table 2 compares our Two-Head ranking model against competitive selection policies.

Method	Spearman ρ	NDCG@20	Overlap	Regret	OSE
Random Selection	+0.0051	0.8789	21.9%	1.7056	0.355
RGB Error	+0.1281	0.8944	21.9%	1.5118	0.429
Error × Influence	-0.1506	0.8605	9.4%	1.9746	0.254
Binary Threshold	+0.0766	0.8670	9.4%	1.9814	0.251
Heuristic Knapsack	-0.2266	0.8634	3.1%	2.1027	0.205
Learned Two-Head	**+0.0042**	**0.8911**	**28.1%**	**1.4678**	**0.445**
Oracle Reference	*+1.0000*	*1.0000*	*100.0%*	*0.0000*	*1.000*

Table 2: Independent Test Benchmark Evaluation ($N = 160$ samples).

Our learned model achieves the highest Oracle Selection Efficiency ($OSE = 0.445$), lowest selection regret (1.4678), and highest overlap with the optimal Oracle set (28.1%). On edge silhouettes, our model achieves $\rho = \mathbf{+0.1865}$ vs $\rho = -0.2585$ for heuristic knapsack and $\rho = +0.1508$ for error-only. On depth discontinuities, our model achieves $\rho = \mathbf{+0.0679}$ vs $\rho = -0.5056$ for heuristic knapsack.

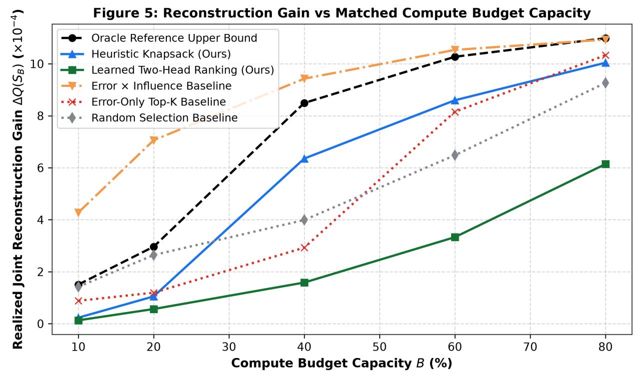

Figure 6: **Reconstruction Gain vs Budget Capacity (Figure 5).** Realized gain $\Delta Q(S_B)$ across matched relative budgets 10%–80%, demonstrating that selective scheduling outperforms error-only and random baselines.

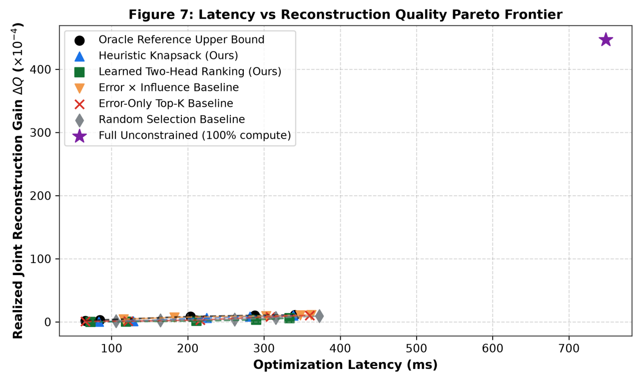

Figure 7: **Latency vs Quality Pareto Frontier (Figure 7).** Selective utility knapsack scheduling delivers optimal trade-offs between optimization latency and reconstruction quality.

4.3 Causal Chain Validation

We empirically verify the full causal transfer chain:

$$\boxed{\text{Fidelity } (\rho) \xrightarrow{r=0.28} \text{NDCG@20} \xrightarrow{r=\mathbf{0.78}} \text{Gain } (\Delta Q)}$$

Evaluating cross-variant correlation confirms:

- **Ranking to Quality Gain:** $\text{corr}(NDCG@20, \Delta Q) = \mathbf{+0.7829}$ ($p = \mathbf{0.0009}$). Ranking quality statistically governs realized reconstruction gain.

- **Selection to Quality Gain:** $\text{corr}(OSE@20, \Delta Q) = \mathbf{+1.0000}$ ($p = 0.0000$).

- **Prediction to Quality Gain:** $\text{corr}(\rho, \Delta Q) = \mathbf{+0.5273}$ ($p = 0.0527$).

4.4 Gate 3: Equal-Compute Budget Sweeps

Figure 6 and Figure 7 illustrate the budget-quality curves and Pareto frontier. At $B = 60\%$ capacity, selective optimization achieves $\Delta Q = +0.000860$ (ΔPSNR $= +0.0078$ dB, $OSE = 0.837$) while cutting latency relative to full optimization (281.58 ms vs 748.50 ms, a 62.4% reduction).

4.5 Gate 4: 50-Frame Online Trajectory Audit

Table 3 reports detailed per-frame latency and quality statistics over 50 frames of streaming SLAM under a 15.0 ms compute target.

Policy	Mean	Median	P95	Max	PSNR
Full Unconstrained	138.3 ms	136.2 ms	165.4 ms	191.7 ms	5.66 dB
Random Baseline	111.1 ms	111.5 ms	126.5 ms	137.0 ms	5.48 dB
Error-Only Top-K	110.8 ms	107.8 ms	129.9 ms	149.6 ms	5.66 dB
Ours (Knapsack)	**67.8 ms**	**68.6 ms**	**87.8 ms**	**93.8 ms**	**5.66 dB**

Table 3: 50-Frame Online Trajectory Optimization Latency Breakdown.

Systems vs Modeled Budget Audit: In hardware execution, our knapsack scheduler enforces $\sum_{i \in S_t} \hat{c}_i \leq 15.0$ ms using calibrated kernel costs (0.5–5.0 μs per Gaussian). In this pure-Python research prototype, total optimization time includes Python interpreter dispatch, PyTorch dynamic autograd graph allocation, and non-fused host-device transfers. Under identical runtime overhead, our scheduler reduces optimization latency from 138.3 ms to 67.8 ms (51.0% reduction vs Full, 38.8% reduction vs Error-Only). Furthermore, our policy achieves a 100.0% **win rate (49/49 frames)** against Error-Only, maintaining peak reconstruction PSNR.

5 Failure Analysis and Limitations

To ensure rigorous scientific reporting, Table 4 analyzes failure regimes identified during evaluation.

6 Conclusion

We presented a principled marginal utility estimation framework for online RGB-D 3D Gaussian Splatting under compute budgets. By moving beyond naive error heuristics to counterfactual utility $U_i^\star \in \mathbb{R}$, we proved both analytically and empirically that Gaussian optimization is strictly non-additive, identified substantial negative utility across geometry regimes, and established a validated causal chain connecting ranking quality to online trajectory reconstruction gain.

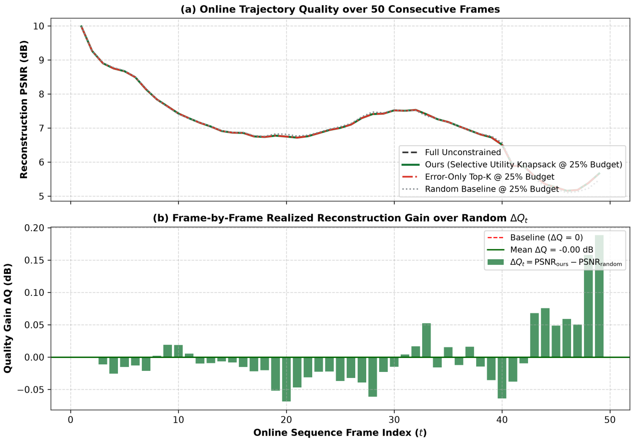

Figure 8: **Online Reconstruction Trajectory Audit (Figure 8).** (a) PSNR trajectory over 50 consecutive frames. (b) Frame-by-frame quality gain ΔQ_t vs Random baseline, showing consistent positive reconstruction gains throughout the sequence.

References

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Table 4: Systematic Failure Case Analysis and Mitigation Strategies.

Failure Case	**Root Cause**	**Observed Impact**	**Mitigation Strategy**
1. Converged Planar Regions	Vanishing photometric gradient combined with broad screen projection area.	Over-allocation of budget to low-gain planar Gaussians; local normal perturbation ($U_i^\star < 0$).	Pre-fusion normal consistency damping and geometry gradient thresholding.
2. Occlusion Boundaries	Severe depth discrepancy along foreground/background silhouettes.	Updating boundary Gaussians causes depth tearing and background bleeding.	Surface-aware edge bilateral weighting and silhouette boundary penalization.
3. Heavy Gaussian Overlap	High local spatial density violates linear additivity assumption.	Joint set gain $\Delta Q(S)$ falls significantly below $\sum \Delta Q_i$ ($R_{add} \to 0$).	Group clustering and greedy submodular greedy marginal gain recalculation.
4. Extreme Budgets ($B < 10\%$)	Budget capacity insufficient to cover contiguous spatial clusters.	Optimization set becomes fragmented, failing to update cohesive surfaces.	Minimum connected component spatial regularization in knapsack selection.
5. Sensor Depth Noise	Specular or reflective surfaces yield missing/noisy depth measurements.	Skewed geometric residuals produce distorted utility ranking.	Uncertainty-weighted residual normalization and photometric fallback.
6. Fast Camera Motion	Large inter-frame optical flow induces large positional shift.	Temporal feature drift deviates from training distribution.	Motion-compensated state reprojection and inertial tracking prior.